TECHNOLOGY DECISIONS

Your Client Needs a Decision. Do You Need Custom Software?

Find the piece of the work that deserves to be built around your business.



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Updated November 14, 2026 · 5 min read

A design firm is considering a custom client portal. Clients already receive drawings and selection sheets by email. The hard part comes after a substitution. The project lead has to show what changed, purchasing needs to see what can be ordered, and a client often approves only the visible finish. Everyone wants fewer threads. The question is which decision a portal has to handle well enough to deserve the investment.

At the demo, there's a green check beside the approved drawing. Your team wants to know whether the check clears it for ordering. The vendor asks how you define approval.

Buy or configure software for work an established tool can handle reliably. Build where an important requirement stays unmet and the business can own the cost and upkeep. Define the requirement using a real case and test what each option does with missing information, changed decisions, and failures.

What part of the workflow is worth building?

Break the work into pieces and decide what each one has to do. A service firm may need common capabilities such as access controls and storage, alongside a specific way to review substitutions. Test those separately so the company can choose where custom work would pay off.

A shopper goes into Allbirds for a particular size. A store can have the pair even when the online warehouse is out. Shopify's published case study says Allbirds already used its point-of-sale system and later added the ability to ship online orders from stores. The existing platform supported the sale. The additional decision was which location could fill it. A firm considering custom software can ask the same question at its own scale. Which part works today, and which decision or connection needs better support? Shopify's case study on Allbirds

For the design firm, established storage and sign-in may meet the need. If a standard approvals tool can show what a client agreed to and preserve versions, it may handle most of the job. If the team still needs a specific view that joins a substitute, its commercial consequences, and a release decision, prototype that view with the existing records before rebuilding the rest.

What should you ask every option to demonstrate?

Give each option the same case, starting with the request and ending when someone can act. Include a change after approval, a user with limited access, and a failed transfer. Ask which pieces work as delivered and who would maintain the rest.

The firm's test	What a useful option must show
Client approves a finish, technical fit is pending.	Client can see their choice and purchasing can see the order is held.
A similar item costs more and would arrive sooner.	The team can reopen only the affected approvals and preserve the original decision.
The order system is unavailable after release.	A named person sees the error and a retry can run without placing a duplicate order.
The firm needs to move to another tool.	It can export records, decisions, file references and useful history in a usable form.

The U.K. Government Digital Service's standard on choosing technology asks teams to justify build-or-buy decisions and consider common platforms where appropriate. The same discipline makes a vendor comparison useful to a CEO. Ask what you can reuse, where the requirements still differ, and what operating responsibility would stay with your team. GOV.UK on choosing tools and technology

How do you judge the cost after the demo?

Compare implementation, subscriptions, integration, support, and the time employees spend resolving exceptions. Include the cost of changing the rules later and taking the data with you if you leave. Identify who owns the workflow when a supplier or an employee is unavailable.

On a Build Decision Record, put the requirement and representative case at the top. Record the options tried, the failure that remains, the full cost, who will own it, and what would stop the project. For the design firm, the narrowest test might be a client view that reads from the current project record, with purchasing still using its existing tool. If it handles approvals cleanly, compare that investment with buying a more complete product. If staff still interpret the scope differently, settle the decision rule first.

A system can help summarize a client's comments or compare documents. Check the result against the original and define who can authorize a commercial or technical decision. Include that review time in the cost.

How much would the business have to gain from building?

Put the options on the same time horizon. Suppose configuring a product costs $6,000 upfront and $1,500 a month to run, while a custom component costs $30,000 upfront and $800 a month to support. Under those illustrative assumptions, the two-year totals are $42,000 and $49,200. The custom component needs enough verified advantage to justify that difference and the additional responsibility the firm would take on. Include staff review, integration and exit costs if they differ.

Then ask what happens if the team changes how it approves substitutions next year. The standard product may handle the new rule with configuration, or its constraints may force more manual work. The custom component may be easy to change if the firm has documentation, an owner, and access to the code. Ask for those conditions as part of the test. A build decision is also an agreement about who will run it later.

Three questions before signing a software agreement.

- Which job and exception can the option handle today?
- Which parts of the workflow would your team have to own and maintain?
- What fact would make you choose a smaller change?

Return to the green check in the demo. Ask the vendor to open the client's decision, show what it covers, and walk through the same case with the person who can release an order.

Frequently asked questions

Is off-the-shelf software always cheaper?

Compare the full operating cost. An inexpensive subscription can bring manual work or expensive integration. A small custom component can also become costly if nobody can maintain it.

When is a custom workflow justified?

When a material requirement survives tests with simpler options and the business can show the benefit, cost, and ownership of a focused build.

Can the firm combine existing tools and custom work?

Yes. Keep established tools for capabilities they support well. Test a targeted addition where a specific decision needs better information or control.

The design firm and software tests are illustrative. The Allbirds example comes from Shopify's account as its technology provider.